indigenous knowledge of cosmological forces. Shaikh Phul, especially, had a formidable reputation as one who could control the planets themselves by invoking divine names and claimed for himself the not inconsiderable miracle of having been escorted by the angel Gabriel through the seven heavens to witness the glory of God. It was in this context that Humayun developed an elaborate court ritual involving dress codes and uniforms, and the use of auspicious names. One of the most visible accoutrements Humayun devised for himself and a few intimate courtiers was a distinctive raised headgear called the Taj-i Izzat, or Crown of Glory. It sent a subtle yet powerfully symbolic message about the sacred nature of Humayun's kingship, a sacrality he reinforced by his ability to read the planets and, as we shall see, his kinship with Ahmad of Jam, a twelfth-century mystic.

In 1538, when Humayun set off on an expedition to Bengal, his brother Hindal lured Shaikh Phul to Benares and had him murdered, in a wordless if bloody acknowledgement of the saint's powers over Humayun*. Sher Khan, ruler of Bihar, sensing weakness, barred Humayun's route and decimated the Mughal army at Chausa. He then took the title Sher Shah Sur, making his ambitions clear. The Padshah's three brothers also joined the fray against Humayun necessitating an escape that would eventually lead the Padshah out of Hindustan altogether. Seeking to travel through Kabul, he asked Kamran for permission which his brother insolently, yet predictably, refused. 'What was the good of my courtesy in showing kindness and brotherliness to the Mirza,' lamented the beleaguered Padshah, 'if he is now talking to me in this way?' Humayun's retainers and supporters slowly deserted him in his wanderings through the badlands of Hindustan—the eternally sparring kingdoms of the Punjab and Sind. His small retinue included the women of his harem, who shared the uncertain fortunes of their Padshah and whose vulnerability had been exposed at the battle of Chausa. Many women were lost at that battle, presumed drowned. Bega Begum, Humayun's most senior wife, was captured by the Afghans and her six-year-old daughter, Aqiqa, was lost.

While Humayun did apply himself for many years to defending the territories his father had left him, there was perhaps something in his very character that prevented him from successfully establishing himself in a violent and merciless world. An account left by his water-bearer Jauhar Aftabchi of the beleaguered Padshah is revealing: